# Rented to Owned Visibility.

A longitudinal study of how small Maldivian tourism businesses are **found, chosen and booked** as discovery shifts to social media and generative AI.

**MTVO.** MALDIVES TOURISM VISIBILITY OBSERVATORY

Piloted in the Maldives, designed to travel.

### 01 Measure

Build and validate a Visibility Index scoring a property across search, booking sites, social media, reviews, AI answers and its own channels.

### 02 Track

Score the same panel of properties monthly for 36 months from October 2027, against a baseline rebuilt from my 2016 fieldwork.

### 03 Explain

Interview owners each season about why numbers moved, and extend resource dependence theory from booking sites to AI intermediaries.

## THE PROBLEM

Small Maldivian guesthouses and independent hotels have long relied on booking platforms to be seen. In my 2016 fieldwork, two owners reported that over 90% of their bookings came through online agents. Now AI assistants are starting to name where to stay, and early studies (mostly preprints) suggest small brands are rarely named. No one tracks this for small island businesses; my 2016 fieldwork lets me rebuild a baseline to measure change against.

## FOUR QUESTIONS

1. Can visibility across all these channels be **measured reliably**, month after month?
2. How does it **change over time**: more rented, or more owned?
3. Which properties do **AI assistants recommend**, and why?
4. Does visibility change **how much of each booking** a business keeps?

## HOW THE INDEX READS VISIBILITY

**RENTED**
Booking sites, AI answers, platform algorithms



*Search, social and reviews sit between: the Index scores where each path ends.*

**OWNED**
Own website, direct messages, email list, repeat guests

## THE GAP

No validated, multi-layer visibility instrument spans search, OTAs, social platforms and generative AI answers, and no study has tracked how small island tourism businesses' visibility and value capture change over time as discovery shifts to algorithmic intermediaries.

## THE PATH

**2016**
Fieldwork on four islands: the baseline

**Jan–Jun 2027**
Public-data pilot and a first working paper

**Sep 2027**
Target start, subject to admission and ethics

**Oct 2027–Sep 2030**
36-month live panel, seasonal interviews

**After the PhD**
The observatory keeps running after submission

## WHAT IT PRODUCES

- **Tool:** a validated, versioned Visibility Index and a free owner dashboard.
- **Theory:** resource dependence extended from booking sites to algorithmic intermediaries.
- **Data:** a monthly visibility and channel panel for tourism SMEs in a small island state; I found no earlier one.

## WHY ME, WHY NOW

15+ years in Maldivian tourism marketing, from resort marketing to SME incubation, and two peer-reviewed guesthouse papers (2017, 2021). AI assistants are starting to broker beds, and no one yet measures it for small island businesses.

## ETHICS AND DECLARED INTEREST

Admission, supervision and ethics approval are still to come, and no results are claimed. Until approval, only public business information is used. I run Islandeative, currently minimal; businesses I advise are excluded from the panel and interviews.

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Structured and fact-checked with AI assistance; the ideas, experience and final wording are the author's to confirm.